

Screen Balance



BIG IDEA Screens can be fun, and so can many other things. I notice how I feel, and I can choose a break. If screens make me sad, mad, worried, or tired, I tell a grown-up.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: 6 feelings face cards, 8 Break Menu cards, a Balance Plate per child (paper plate in 4 wedges, or the printed page 2), crayons, a chime, the Hackles Certificate.

- ☐ Use the printed Balance Plate (page 2) for zero prep.
- ☐ Fill in the Hackles Certificates, or let children write their own names.
- ☐ Find the chime.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Hold up the Lily card and a feelings face card. “Lily loves her tablet. Videos, music, games. But after a long time on it, her tummy felt grumpy and her eyes felt tired. She did not know why. Have you ever felt grumpy like that? (*Accept nods.*) That’s normal. It means our body wants something different. Hackle says: **screens can be fun, and so can other things.** Playing outside, drawing, singing, hugging a pet. Today we **notice how we feel** and **choose a break.** And if a screen ever makes you feel sad, mad, worried or scared, you can tell a grown-up. It is not your fault, and you will not be in trouble.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *My Balance Plate*

- 1 (2 min) Feelings check-in.** Copy each face. “Our feelings are clues.”
- 2 (2 min) The Break Menu.** Act out each of the 8 cards (stretch, sing, draw in the air). Teach: “I need a break.”
- 3 (3 min) My Balance Plate.** Four wedges: moving or playing, people, quiet things, screens. “Screens are one wedge, not the whole plate.”
- 4 (1 min) Chime break.** Ring it, put crayons down, three slow breaths, stretch.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “How can your body tell you it’s time for a break?” (Tired eyes, grumpy, wiggly.)
- 2** “What if a screen makes you feel sad, mad, or worried?” (Tell a grown-up. Not my fault.)
- 3** “What if it’s hard to stop?” (Say “I need help to stop,” and pick a break.)

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Screens are one part of my day. I notice how I feel and choose a break. If something online makes me worried, I tell a grown-up.” Then the certificate: “You are officially a **Hackles Champ!**”

Hand signal: Pause and notice my feelings (palm). **Check:** do I need a break? (eyes). **Tell** (hand on heart, reach out).

EXIT TICKET Circle the face that shows how you feel after too long on a screen. Draw a **break** you would pick.

FUN BOOST Plate Dance (30 seconds). Call a wedge; everyone does it for 10 seconds: Move, People, Quiet, Screen (freeze like a robot). End with a wobbly one-foot “balance!”

LEVEL-UP Family Break. Pick one Break Menu idea to do with a grown-up this week.

DIFFERENTIATE Use three feelings faces and four Break Menu cards. Do not judge screen time at home; everyone’s day is different.

FAMILY CARD Ask: “How does your body feel after a screen? What break would you choose?” If anything online worries them, they can tell you.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me.”
- “I believe you. It is not your fault.”
- “I will get help from someone whose job is to keep kids safe.”

- **Do not say:** “I promise I won’t tell anyone.”
- “Why didn’t you tell me sooner?” or “Are you sure?”
- Any leading question (“Did he touch you?”).

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.